The Mihai Eminescu Trust Newsletter, 2010

About the Mihai Eminescu Trust



The Trust works to preserve and revitalize the cultural, historic and natural heritage of South-East Transylvania. The communist regime and the subsequent exodus of the Saxon population that lived here for hundreds of years led these villages to a loss of identity and massive destruction. Our aim is to save the precious cultural heritage of these villages and revitalize the local communities. In our over 10-year experience we deployed over 600 projects in 25 villages and 4 towns.

We choose, develop and manage projects together with the local communities. This way we make sure that they respond to real local needs and that their beneficiaries are truly committed. For all projects we use only traditional construction materials and techniques, and the works are conducted by locals.

As such, we trained over 150 locals in masonry, carpentry, joinery, iron work, tile and brick making. Receiving training and official qualifications allows them to make a stable income and remain in their villages.









We set up 3 blacksmith workshops, 2 brick and tile kilns, 2 carpentry workshops and one lime pit. These were transferred to local craftsmen who now manage them successfully.

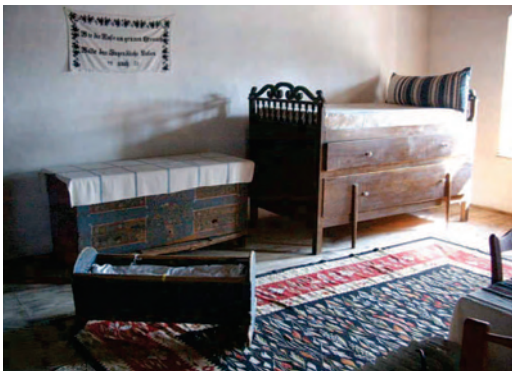






The guesthouses provide high quality services and traditional organic food. Thousands of tourists spend their holidays here every year in search of an authentic rural experience.







In every village, we support the development of cultural tourism. We trained 40 local ladies as tourism operators.

The First Training Center for Crafts in Romania

In 2009-2010, thanks to Horizon Foundation, The Trust saved from demolition and restored the old school in Alma Vii village, Sibiu county. This historic building was turned into a Training Center for Crafts and a Heritage Information Center. The building can accommodate over 7 people, as it contains 2 bedrooms, 3 bathrooms and a kitchen.

Here, village inhabitants will be trained in masonry, carpentry, ironwork and so on. Over 30 trainees are currently attending courses here. The center will also provide training in agro-tourism, traditional food processing, English, accounting (destined especially to local guesthouse operators).

The center will also be open to trainees from the urban environment. Universities, corporations, schools will be able to hold seminars, courses, conferences, team building activities, summer schools and camps.



November 2008 **July 2009** **June 2010**

The Information Center an extensive library of best practice materials regarding cultural heritage, as well as internet access. Here we provide free counseling to locals and visitors regarding heritage conservation and development.



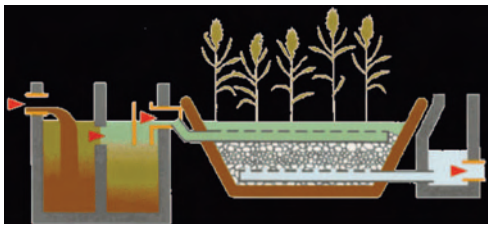
In November 2010, the Center hosted a workshop on heritage conservation and rural regeneration that reunited over 30 regional and national level experts.



The First Ecological Water Purification Station in Romania



The Trust built the station in 2010 in Viscri village, Brasov county, together with the local community who put in valuable volunteer work. Financing was ensured by The Prince's Charities Foundation and Rompetrol Romania.



This is a truly innovative system, as waste waters from the local households are purified through nature. Wastewaters go into an ensemble of artificial lakes, where they are purified through the natural process of soil infiltration and through the influence of aquatic plants (reed), returning clear into nature. This pioneer project can be implemented in other villages as well.

Its advantages are not only its environment-friendly character, but also its flexibility to changes (it acts like a live organism) and the low construction and exploitation costs.

Restoration of Cojocarilor Tower (Sighisoara, Mures county)

After more than two years of historic, archaeological and architectural surveys, the MET has launched the restoration of one of Sighisoara's iconic fortification towers, adjacent to the Trust's Romanian office inside the World Heritage mediaeval citadel.

The building is located on the western edge of the citadel, near the Butchers' Tower and was built, extended and rebuilt extensively between the 15th and the 17th century.







Cojocarilor Tower - before

With the help of Colin Richards, his team of Shropshire conservation experts and construction workers from BMT Trans Medias, we started to remove the cement render applied to the lower part of the tower in the 1960s, discovering old graffiti from the 1800s embedded underneath.

On the surface there is evidence of the defensive role of the tower, which bears the marks of bullet and musket ball holes. Excavations have started for the foundations of the external staircase, under the supervision of UK archaeologist Mick Krupa and the archaeology officer of the Sighisoara Town Hall.



Colin Richards
and
Stefan Balici



Cojocarilor TOWER – during (May – June 2010)





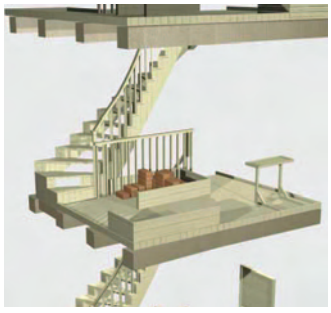


Colin Richards:`*This unique partnership between Shropshire Council and the Mihai Eminescu Trust creates an intense professional and personal learning experience for all those involved, where heritage professionals from the UK and Romania can enhance each others competences through the conservation of a building heritage of international significance".*





Cojocarilor tower – after (fall 2010)





After completing the restoration Mihai Eminescu Trust will open it up to the public as an exhibition space demonstrating traditional craft skills and conservation of Transylvania's historic built heritage to inform both current and future generations.

«Transylvania-Heritage and Future» Exhibition in Washington

The exhibition was presented in Washington DC in the period 14 – 31 October at the Romanian Embassy. The event was organized with the kind support of the Romanian Embassy in Washington, the Romanian Cultural Institute in New York, the Ministry of Tourism and Regional Development and the Ratiu Foundation.

The exhibition rejoiced a large number of participants, among which important personalities from politics and culture, such as Ambassadors Adrian Vierita and Carl Gershman and Prof. Eliot Sorel. The event generated enthusiasm among the American public, who was very interested to discover and support the extraordinary heritage values of South-Eastern Transylvania.







Jessica Douglas-Home President of the Trust and Caroline Fernolend Vice-president presented the history and transformation of the deserted Saxon villages into the blooming self-sustainable communities that they are today. The presentation of the Jewish culture in Transylvania and the Open Forum also enjoyed great success.

The Great Award of the Civil Society Gala

In May, the Trust was honored to receive the Great award at the Civil Society Gala 2010. This is the highest distinction awarded in Romania for contribution to culture and society development. The Award was offered to the Trust for our 10-years work in revitalizing 10 villages in Transylvania.

The Trust's "Whole Village Project" also received the 1° Price at Art & Culture category. As for our environmental projects, we were awarded the 3° Price for our reforestation projects conducted with the schools in rural communities.







In December, Caroline Fernolend was awarded the trophy "A Perfect 10 for Romania". This distinction is awarded by the Romanian media to people who made a strong contribution to the development of the country.

The winners were famous personalities from art, politics, medicine, education, sports, so we were honored to be among them.

Award "A Perfect 10 for Romania"



«Skopationsfest» revived on the Breite Oak Tree Reserve

The Breite Oak Tree Reserve near Sighişoara (Mureş county) contains one of the largest and best preserved ancient oak tree collections in Central and Eastern Europe – trees 700-800 years old. This reserve has a great emotional value for the local community. For hundreds of years, the town inhabitants organized here an important spring feast, which was ceased by the communist regime.

After 70 years, the Trust revived this fest in May 2010, as a genuinely cultural and ecological event created for the local community. We rejoiced a great number of participants – over 300 children, youngsters and adults. They enjoyed creative workshops, nature exploration trips and traditional fanfare music. The festival reunited over 30 local artists and craftsmen who shared their knowledge and passion with the participants.





The Largest Tree in South-Eastern Transylvania Identified

The Trust organized a contest challenging the children from the rural environment to seek and find the largest tree in their area. An impressive number of over 400 children from 3 counties (Sibiu, Mureș and Brașov) participated.



Two children identified on the oak plateau near Mercheașa village (Brașov county) an impressive oak that according to our knowledge is the largest and oldest oak in Southern Transylvania and may be a good candidate for the largest oak in Romania.

This veteran oak measures 9.30 meters in circumference and has an estimated age of 900 years. All participants were rewarded with eco-branded presents.





Ancient Oak Plateau Declared Protected Area

Wood pastures with veteran oaks are a symbol for the culture and tradition of Transylvania. Unfortunately they are threatened to disappear due to human indifference and cease of traditiona land-use practices.

The Trust evaluated over 30 wood pastures in Transylvania and worked with the local communities to raise awareness regarding their protection.

As a consequence, the Ancient Oak Tree Plateau of the Fișer village (Brașov county) and its 76 veteran trees will obtain official recognition as natural monuments and a protective statute.



Restoration of the Apafi Manor

This highly valuable historic building dates from the XV century, and it was the former residence of the Hungarian noble family Apafy. It is located in Malancrav village, Sibiu county. During communism and in the following years (for almost a century), it was abandoned and reached the verge of destruction.

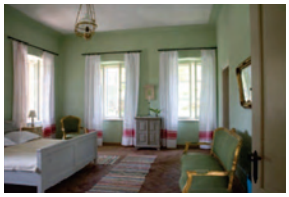
The Trust purchased it and began its renovation and reconstruction in 2000. The project lasted for 4 years and involved a large team of excellent local and foreign specialists and craftsmen.



The impressive building now comprises 9 rooms, a saloon, a library and a kitchen. Traditional decorations, books and furniture were donated by benefactors and by the local community, beautifully completing this wonderful edifice.

The manor is surrounded beautifully arranged by gardens, that maintain the original design and atmosphere.









The Manor is open for guided tours and accommodation, traditional meals being provided by the local inhabitants of the village. Also, the Manor often hosts cultural and social events such as: seminars, conferences, concerts, local traditional celebrations and traditional brunches.

The Landscape Ecology group of the Mihai Eminescu Trust

This group was formed in 2008 as recognition of the huge ecological and cultural importance of the “landscape heritage” of the Saxon area of Southern Transylvania. The outstanding biodiversity of this region includes around 1400 species of plants, more than 300 species of butterflies, 12 species of amphibians, more than 100 species of birds, large carnivores (bears and wolves) from which many species shows dramatic decline in some countries from Western Europe being now considered protected. The aim of this group is to promote and conduct research to better understand the status and spatio-temporal dynamic of natural populations and communities in these landscapes and the various links between the landuse and biodiversity. The results of these studies were already published in more than 60 scientific papers from which 20 were published in international journals having Impact Factor including top ranked conservation journals.









The Mihai Eminescu Trust is attractive for foreign institutions as well. One major project in this respect was started in November 2010 in partnership with the Leuphana University Lueneburg and it is entitled: “Fostering sustainable development in Eastern Europe: A case study of ancient agricultural landscapes in Central Romania”.

This project is lead by Professor Joern Fischer. This research will map biodiversity and the ecosystem services generated by it, and will identify formal and informal institutions that can provide leverage points for enabling sustainable land use practices.



Contest for Best Newsletter Title



The Mihai Eminescu Trust is looking for the most inspired title for our annual newsletter. Send your idea to us at admin@mihaieminescutrust.org by January 31, 2011 and enter the competition for the winning title!

The received proposals will be assessed by the MET team, and the winner will be announced in February 2011 on the website www.mihaieminescutrust.org. The lucky winner will be awarded a $ 100 prize!

Eligible participants are the residents of the Saxon villages in Transylvania, local mass-media, people and organizations that activate for the conservation of the Saxon heritage in Transylvania. The MET staff and their families cannot participate in the contest.





The Mihai Eminescu Trust Wishes all our Friends and Collaborators a Merry Christmas and a Happy New Year

None of our work would have been possible without the exceptionally generous support of the Packard Humanities Institute in California. We would also like to express our gratitude to all the institutions and organizations who supported and financed the projects presented in this newsletter: The Prince's Charities Foundation, EEA Grants, Citibank, Horizon Foundation, Hedley Trust, The Ministry of Finance, The Romanian Embassy in Washington, The Romanian Cultural Institute in New York, the Ministry of Tourism and Regional Development, The Ratiu Foundation, Rompetrol Romania.

The achievements in this newsletter are only made possible by your donations. We are a listed charity, No 1107300.

Donations can be made to the accounts of the Trust opened at Raiffeisen Bank Sighişoara: R009 RZBR 0000 0600 07815230 (Lei account) and RO51 RZBR 0000 0600 07815250 (Euro account).

Cheques can be sent to our London office: 38 Hazel Road, London NW10 5PP / Tel. +44(0) 20 89628621. Donations made in the UK qualify for gift aid.

For any information about our activities as well as books or brochures, please contact our Romanian Office at the following address: 10 Cojocarilor Str., Sighisoara, Mures County, Romania; Tel: +40 (0)265 506024, E-mail: admin@mihaieminescutrust.org; or visit our website www.mihaieminescutrust.org.

For guesthouse bookings please contact us at Tel. +40 (0)754212372 or leave us a message at guesthouses@mihaieminescutrust.org.